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Directing Narrative in Gameplay

Player Interaction in shaping narrative in the Witcher 3

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ABSTRACT

The overall aim of this research was to explore how players interact with narrative in videogames. This paper reports on results from a diary study over a two-week period while playing one narrative-drive game. An analysis of participants' diary entries suggests that those who engaged in directing narrative activities in The Witcher 3 described their interactions in three key ways: passive interaction, active interaction, and dialogue choices. These results demonstrate the combined narrative structures (linear and branching) in The Witcher 3. The identified interactions also represent the narrative as a gameplay element given how players describe interacting with story element even when completing other activities.

CCS CONCEPTS

Applied computing → Computers in other domains →
Personal computers and PC applications → Computer
games

KEYWORDS

Videogame, Interactive Narrative, Interactive Choices

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1 Introduction

Narrative is an important element of videogames, providing players with a context for their in-game actions, rules and goals [9; 18; 34]. Narrative can also provide the player with motivations, purpose for their actions [34], and create emotion [18]. In an increasing number of modern games (e.g. The Mass Effect Series [3], The Witcher

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Series [7]), a players' direct interaction with the game's narrative helps shape how the story progresses.

This paper examines player engagement in activities, focusing on their interactions with narrative-based gameplay, also known as directing narrative activities. The overall aim of the research is to better understand how players engage in game- and player-driven narrative gameplay activities. The objective of the research is to frame narrative gameplay in a way that may assist researchers and designers to better understand variations in the way players approach rich narrative driven player experiences. This framing of narrative gameplay emerges through an analysis of results of the Games Experience (GExp) study of one narrative rich game, The Witcher 3 (TW3).

The GExp study involved experience sampling that utilised a diary method to gather the in-context experiences of participants playing videogames. Results from the GExp study show the different ways players interact with game narrative in TW3 and provides insights into how players describe these interactions. This detailed examination of gameplay involving narrative contributes to our understanding of player experience (PX) and provides an insight into the modes of interaction that the player may engage in when shaping a game's narrative. In future, the results from this study will form the basis of narrative gameplay analyses across a range of different games.

2 Videogame Narrative

Narrative within videogames is described as a representation of characters in chronological events connected with choices that could change the events of the narrative [23]. The sequence should progress through various conflicts to a final conclusion or conclusions depending on the player's play style [14; 26].

The way that this progress can be presented to the player differs in four major ways. Brand and Knight [6] developed what they refer to as a "Nexus of videogame narrative", where narrative is portrayed to the player as embedded, emergent, evoked and enacted. Embedded narratives occur when environmental elements present the story to the player. The Witcher 3 [7] is an example of embedded narrative with grisly scenery reflecting the games war-related narrative. Emergent narrative is created by the player, typically in sandbox games such as Minecraft [27]. In more structured narrative games, such as in Star Wars Battlefront [12], players have the ability to take authorial control of an existing narrative structure in an evoked narrative. Enacted narratives are

created when the player's interaction with the game determines the progression of the story, through gameplay, cutscenes and cinematics [6]. For example, in *The Walking Dead* [31], the player chooses who lives and who dies between two non-player characters (NPC), this done via a quick-time event where the player is prompted to press a series of buttons during a cutscene. How well the player follows these button prompts determines the outcome of the cutscene.

2.1 Interactive Narrative

Interactive narrative refers to narratives where the player is given some authorial control over the direction of narrative space [5; 10], for example directing the story outcomes, impacting NPCs, and shaping the game world. The concept of interactive narrative has been historically contentious one, where some authors believe that narrative is separate to gameplay [18; 24], while others place narratives as a part of the gameplay [22]. Games with interactive narratives place the player as a character in the game world where their interactions with the game can affect the story structure [17]. How games present an interactive narrative can vary in two different ways, with linear and branching structures. Linear structures are displayed by singular choices leading to the same ending [17]. While players can interact with the narrative by completing portions of gameplay, due to the game's linear structure the player makes no impact on the narrative outcome. A branching structure allows for the players to engage directly with the narrative by completing quests and engaging with dialogue choices which shape the outcome of the game. For example, choosing between mages or templars (*Dragon Age: Inquisition* [4]) or failing prompts and allowing someone to die (*Until Dawn* [30]).

Questing in videogames acts as a bridge between narrative and gameplay [16; 19]. Howard [16] defines five major types of quests – (1) fetch quests focusing retrieving items, (2) delivery quests where the player needs to deliver an item, (3) kill quests where the player is sent to kill something, (4) dungeon crawlers where the player is sent to kill all creatures in a particular location, and (5) escort quests which involve the player protecting a vulnerable non-player character (NPC) or item. By completing quests, the outcomes may contribute to a videogame's main narrative or questline or associated 'side-quests' [16].

In terms of function, conversations with NPCs can provide players with an interface for interaction [28]. Dialogue wheels or conversation trees allows players to make decisions in dialogue, which offers players a direct influence on the game's narrative. NPCs in the *Mass Effect* [3] universe react differently to the player character and can offer them different dialogue options depending on the player's choice of paragon or renegade behaviours in the game. Dialogue choice can also have no overall effect on the game's outcomes, giving the player an illusion of choice [13]. For example, in *Horizon Zero Dawn* [15], the player is given dialogue choices in terms of compassion, strategic or aggressive dialogue but these choices have no apparent impact on the direction or outcomes of the story.

3 Method

While thirty participants took part in the larger Games Experience (GExp) diary study, this paper focuses on the participants who played *The Witcher 3* (TW3) as a part of the study.

3.1 Participants

While 12 participants played *The Witcher 3* in the GExp study, only 10 reported engaging in Directing Narrative activities. It is data from these participants that form the basis of our data analysis. The twelve participants who played TW3 seven were male and 5 were females, and a majority of the participants were aged between 21-29 years (21-29 n=8; age 18-20 n=1; age 30-39 n=3). Participants were recruited for the study based on their interest in games and willingness to take part in a two-week study and meet the diary submission requirements. Participant recruitment was as completed online via several Facebook groups targeting people who play videogames, but with varying levels of game playing experience. Of the ten participants, who reported engaging in Directing Narrative activities, five participants described having played TW3 prior to the study, while five participants had no experience with the game (see **Error! Reference source not found.** for a list of participants).

Table 1: Participants previous experience playing TW3

Participant	3	4	21	22	23	24	26	27	28	29
Yes (Y)	Y	N	N	Y	N	N	Y	Y	Y	N
No (N)										

3.2 GExp Procedure

This section outlines the procedure of GExp including the narrative elements of *The Witcher 3* which made it ideal for examination in this study, and the procedure followed for participants in the diary study.

3.2.1 Narrative in *The Witcher 3*

The main questline follows the adventures of Geralt, a witcher (monster hunter), as he searches for his adoptive daughter in the middle of a war. The game evokes narrative elements from the previous two *Witcher* games and the books that the games were originally based on [29]. TW3 contains enacted narrative where the player can complete quests, engage in dialogue choices, and watch cinematic cutscenes. The game provides for a small amount of emergent narrative as the player can shape the outcome of the story in terms of the player character's love interest, political alignment, life or death of various key NPCs, and the fate of Geralt's daughter. Given the number of different choices that the player can make throughout the game, they may be considered emergent choice, however these choices are usually made through directing interaction with the game which is representative of enact narrative. Finally, due to the detailed open-world environment, TW3 has a

rich representation of embedded narrative. For example, in one of the three maps, the country is experiencing war and famine, this conveyed to the player through background conversations happening between NPCs, and the bloody battlefield that fill the environment.

3.2.1 GExp Diary Study

Study participants were asked to play TW3 for a minimum of 1-hour, three-times per week for two weeks, and complete an online journal within 30-minutes after each play session. The online diary was broken down in a series of questions centred on participants' experience of activities in videogames. Participants were asked to describe the primary type of play they engaged in during their play session in relation to one of twelve activity types: including Conflict, Exploration, Conceptual Reasoning, Physical Coordination, etc (cf. [2]); and Directing Narrative and Role-Playing (cf. [25]). This paper will focus on the reported experiences from the Directing Narrative category.

4 Results

Activities that were identified most frequently by participants who played TW3 as a part of the GExp, include Exploration (n=26), Conflict (n=20) and Directing Narrative (n=15). Directing Narrative activities are the focus of this paper and were selected fifteen times by ten study participants.

Diary entry data was analysed using a thematic approach by a single researcher. Each entry was coded and these codes were grouped into the thematic groups presented in this paper. Three key themes that emerged from entries relating to Directing Narrative in TW3 include Dialogue choices, Active Interaction and Passive Interaction (see Figure 1).

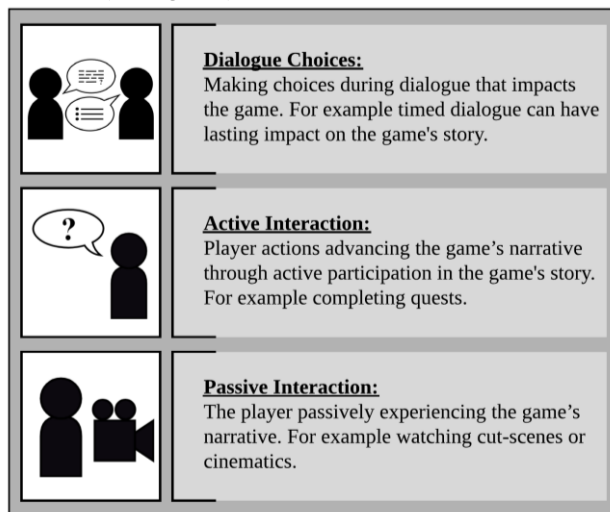


Figure 1: Themes emerged from Directing Narrative.

Dialogue choices were one of the themes that the interactions that players had while shaping the game's narrative (Participants 21, 22, 26, and 28). The example quotes below demonstrate how participants' experiences of dialogue choices and dialogue

decisions shaped the narrative of the world. There was a focus on creating relationships with NPCs and impacting story outcomes;

“Most of my time in this play session was spent in dialogues... The choices had impacts such as forging relationships with recurring NPCs...” – **Participant 22**

According to Participant 22, building a strong relationship with characters can help unlock other quests further in the story and progress Geralt's (the PC) personal romance. Participant 26 having played TW3 before using their ideal personal choices for the player character, decided that they would make dialogue choices that contradicted their initial playthrough.

“Thinking through dialogue options and deciding what will make Vlodimir and Shani happy so that I get the best story outcomes...” – **Participant 26**

Participant 26 strives to make *Vlodimir and Shani (NPCs)* happy in the game, there is the implication that they could also make the opposite choice and make the character unhappy.

“In talking to them they would prompt me to make decisions about how I would treat the situation, sometimes requiring me to act quickly or the choice would be taken away from me.” – **Participant 21**

In active story interaction, participants (Participants 22, 23, 27, 28, and 29) were actively involved in moving the story forward. Participant quotes demonstrate how the activity is driven by a game's narrative more generally, rather than through specific dialogue choices. For example, players engage with quests that create progression through the narrative.

“Unlocking new narrative options - by completing this main quest, the story progressed and new options came up.” – **Participant 28**

“...The Keira Metze quest line. After you do the Wandering in the Dark quest, she'll say you should come round and "visit" some time. So you go visit and she wants you to do another quest. So you do the quest.” – **Participant 29**

“Mainly completing quests and talking to people of towns to discover quests and go further on already active quests.” – **Participant 27**

Passive interaction was described by participants as relating to the story as presented by the game system, rather than shaping the narrative through activity, as well as quests or making decisions related to conversations that they'd had with non-player characters. Participants 3 and 4 describe cinematics, cut-scenes or pre-scripted dialogue sequences. In these experiences, the story was moving forward but the participants were passively involved in watching it happen.

“I was listening to more of the story as to why the Bloody Barons wife and daughter ran away.” – **Participant 4**

“The game's setting the tone and explaining important parts of the story. It involves travelling to different areas

and engaging in conversation with different NPCs, driving this part of the story forward.” – **Participant 3**

In TW3, cut-scenes can be seen as a result or reward for player decisions in dialogue, and generally represents the narrative progression in the game therefore they are a more passive experience.

5 Discussion

The majority of participants (10 out of 12) identified directing narrative as their primary activity when playing TW3. This demonstrates the importance of narrative in the gameplay experience of this particular game. Interactive narrative choices are designed to facilitate engagement in videogames [11]. In TW3, the player’s narrative choices can often impact on the direction of the game’s narrative. The player can often decide moral choices and relationships through the player-character (PC). Players’ interactions with the narrative were described by GExp participants in three key themes: **passive interaction**, **active interaction** and **dialogue choices**.

5.1 Enacted Narrative

Passive interaction with the narrative was described as relating to the game’s story through conversations (with no impactful choices) and cut-scenes. In Brand and Knight’s [6] Nexus of game narrative, cut-scenes were a part of the enacted narrative style [6]. While participants were passively experiencing cutscenes and dialogue with no impact, these cinematic sequences represent progression in the games story. These portions of the narrative where the player passively interacts with the narrative may be presentative of linear portions of the game’s narrative, or even a reward for an earlier narrative choice.

Active engagement with the game’s story included engaging in quests to further the game’s narrative. Enacted narrative (beyond the passive experience described above) may offer modes of interaction within the game’s narrative in a number of ways, including participating in quests. Questing has been identified as a bridge between narrative and gameplay [16; 19]. Quests can contribute to a games’ main narrative or questline or offer some other contribution to the games’ sub-narrative through side-quests [16]. While these activities may be perceived as a part of other broader gameplay activity categories (e.g., Conflict, Exploration), participants still chose Directing Narrative as their primary play experience. This indicates that they felt that they were *primarily engaged* in the directing the game’s narrative outcomes.

5.2 Character Development in Dialogue

According to Crawford [10], narratives are about people and their journeys. Given this, characters and character development are important to the development of a narrative. This may explain the importance of dialogue choices in narrative driven games, particularly those choices that shape the character’s outcome. A number of participants who engaged in Directing Narrative activities in TW3 referred to dialogue choices in the game (eg.

Participants 22 and 26). Dialogue in some games can provide players with moral dilemmas [32], this can be seen in TW3 where different dialogue choices can be seen to make NPCs ‘happy’ (e.g. Participant 26’s experience) this may indicate a level of relatedness where players feel attached or invested in the outcomes for the game’s NPCs [32].

5.3 Linear and Branching Narrative

Dialogue choices and the ability to influence the game’s narrative through actions are what moves games from linear ‘narratives, into interactive experiences [8]. The ability to choose which quests to take or making dialogue choices shape the outcome of the game, may also be consider as a part of the emergent narrative Nexus [6]. Through these interactions, the player can create combinations of choices and decisions to create unique narrative experience. Different players may choose a different lover and personality for the PC, make different choices that impact the end game. Having the option to impact the narrative in a variety of different ways may improve the replayability of the game [1].

5.4 Limitations and Future Work

These themes may be representative of the type of narrative in TW3, where portions are branching and other portions are linear and may only be representative of the experiences of participants playing TW3. Other narrative-driven games may have different methods of interaction that shape the player experience differently. For example, Mass Effect’s Paragon/Renegade behavioral dialogue paradigms, or reputation/faction systems from the Elder Scrolls or Fallout series may offer different modes for interaction in the game’s narrative.

Future research may focus on player interaction in other narrative-driven videogames, and how the ability to interact with narrative shapes the player experience. Narrative has been seen as a motivation for players seeking immersion in videogames [21; 33; 35]. The game design literature included here refers to player’s desire to impact on a game’s story [20]. This is consistent with the results of this study where participants describe engaging in quests to impact the narrative’s progression, and directly impacting the game’s story through dialogue choices.

6 Conclusion

The aim of this research was to explore how players interact with narrative in narrative-driven games. Narrative in videogames has traditionally been used to provide context for gameplay, but in interactive narratives, the player can have a more defined impact on the game’s narrative progression. This research found participants experienced interaction with the Witcher 3’s narrative in three key ways: **passive interactions**, **active interactions**, and **dialogue choices**. These themes provide an insight into how players can interact with a game’s narrative and helps develop an understanding of player interaction and experience of videogame activities. From the different narrative interactions that players do in TW3, there is also a representation of how player interaction can shape the narrative outcomes.

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